Exploration – Watches and keeping guard during a rest · SRD 5.2.1

A **Long Rest** lasts at least **8 hours**: at least 6 hours of sleep and up to 2 hours of **light activity** (watching, reading, talking). **Watches** split this vigil so one character stays alert while the others sleep.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. Long Rest: **8 hours**, at least 6 of sleep.
2. Interrupted by **1 hour** of strenuous activity.
3. One Long Rest per **24 hours**; you need **1 HP**.
4. The watcher uses **passive Perception**.

⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 keeps the Long Rest duration and clarifies that watching counts as light activity.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The SRD doesn't say how to set up watches. Fix: split the night into equal shifts (next table).

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe the night: crackling fire, distant noises, moving shadows.

Step 1 – Camp:

Pick a spot, light a fire or not, decide who keeps watch.

Step 2 – Split:

Divide 8 hours by the number of watchers (see table).

Step 3 – Watch:

The watcher uses **passive Perception** or the Search action.

Step 4 – Event:

On a threat, the DM wakes sleepers; waking someone takes an action.

Step 5 – Conclude:

1 hour of strenuous activity interrupts the rest; otherwise Long Rest benefits apply.

Example: with 4 characters, the night splits into 4 two-hour shifts. On the 3rd, Ilsa (passive Perception 15) spots footsteps.

Watchers	Shift length	Watchers	Shift length
2	4 h	5	1 h 36
3	2 h 40	6	1 h 20
4	2 h	7	1 h 09

⚠ Common questions:

How long is a Long Rest?
8 hours.

How much sleep?
At least 6 hours.

Does watching count?
Yes, as light activity (up to 2 hours).

What interrupts the rest?
1 hour of walking, fighting or casting.

Do I need 1 HP?
Yes, to benefit from a Long Rest.

And elves?
Trance: a Long Rest in 4 hours.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Lone watcher
Is one watcher enough? **Option**: two at night.

Campfire
Does it attract monsters? **Option**: yes, +5 to enemy Perception.

Armored sleep
Sleeping in heavy armor. **Option**: poor sleep, 1 exhaustion level.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Long Rest
One per 24 hours, minimum 1 HP.

Passive Perception
The watcher needn't roll.

Interruption
An hour of strenuous activity restarts the rest.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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